

EMBLEM OF MANHATTAN

Dominating the city's skyline, the Empire State Building stands on Fifth Avenue in the Midtown South district of Manhattan.



Empire State Building

A New York icon, built in just 1 year and 45 days in a race to the sky



The Chrysler Building (see opposite) might win prizes for its beauty, but it is the Empire State Building that can claim to be New York's most iconic building. Ever since it opened on May 1, 1931—just 20 months after contracts had been signed with its architects, Shreve, Lamb, and Harmon Associates—the Empire State has defined the city skyline, featuring in countless movies and photographs. At 1,250 ft (381 m) high, it was the tallest building in the world until it was overtaken by the World Trade Center in 1970. Yet it has not always been so popular. In its first year of opening, which coincided with the worst effects of the Great Depression, only 23 percent of its available space was occupied, which gave it the nickname “the Empty State Building.”

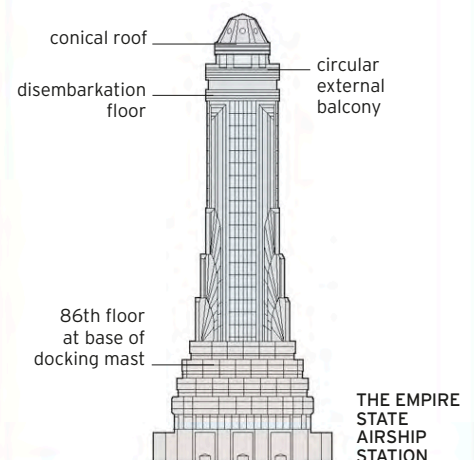
Deco exterior and details

Structurally, the 102-story building is a steel frame covered with 10 million bricks and 730 tons (660 tonnes) of aluminum and stainless steel. Its stepped, uncompromisingly modern Art Deco form is complemented by interior details, including the ceiling murals in the lobby that depict the mechanical wonders of the modern age in gold and aluminum leaf. The exterior of the tower comes to life when it is floodlit every evening.



DOCKING STATION

The top 200 ft (61 m) of the Empire State Building was originally intended to serve as a mooring mast for airships. It was planned that elevators would take passengers up to the 102nd floor, where they would board the airships via a gangplank. The scheme proved completely fanciful—no airship was ever able to moor safely—and was abandoned, after which a radio antenna was fixed to the peak of the docking station.



LOBBY MURAL

An aluminum mural of the building, without its antenna but with rays of light beaming from its pinnacle, decorates a wall in the entrance lobby.